# Effective Paragraph Writing

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Functional English (SS1012)

# What is a paragraph?

A **paragraph** is a short piece of writing that presents a main point and supports it.

A paragraph consists of a **topic sentence** that states your main point, **body sentences** that support your main point, and a **concluding sentence** that reminds readers of your main point and makes an observation.

# Effective Paragraphs

- Effective paragraphs exhibit four qualities of good writing:
  - **Unity**
  - **Development**
  - **Organization**
  - **Coherence**

# 1-Unity

- The paragraph centers on ONE MAIN IDEA, and all the details stick to the central topic.
- The key to unity in the paragraph is the TOPIC SENTENCE.

# Topic Sentence

- The most general statement in the paragraph
- Contains the heart of all the ideas to be explored
- Helpful for the reader if it contains some clues about organization
- SUBJECT + COMMENT

# Consider these topic sentences:

- It takes a lot to be ready for college.

- Notice this sentence is vague, with an unfocused subject (“to be ready for college”) and a vague comment (“it takes a lot”).

# Better

- In preparing for college, a wise student will observe three crucial principles of good planning.

- Subject is clear (but could be narrower!) and the focus is straightforward—we know where the paragraph will go.

# 2-Development

- Adding specific details
- Major supports: the central points that directly support the topic sentence
- Minor supports: specific details that help develop your major supports

# For example:

- In preparing for college, a wise student will observe three crucial principles of good planning.
- The three crucial principles will be the major supports.
- The details and examples of each principle will be the minor supports.

# 3-Organization:
# Three Main Paragraph Structures

**Paragraph structures based on reasoning and organization can be classified as:**

1. Deductive Paragraph
2. Inductive Paragraph
3. Complex Paragraph

# 1. Deductive Paragraph

**(General → Specific)**

- The **main idea or topic sentence** comes **at the beginning**.
- The rest of the paragraph provides **supporting details, examples, or evidence**.
- This is the **most common** structure in academic and formal writing because it is clear and direct.

✅ **Example:**

*Online education is an effective alternative to traditional learning. It allows flexibility in scheduling, provides access to diverse resources, and supports different learning styles.*

**Structure:**

Topic sentence → Supporting details → Examples → (Optional conclusion)

# 2. Inductive Paragraph

**(Specific → General)**

- Begins with **examples, facts, or specific details**, leading to a **conclusion or general statement** at the end.
- Used when you want to **build up to a main idea** or let the reader **infer your conclusion**.

**Example:**

*Students attend virtual lectures, complete online quizzes, and participate in discussion boards from home. They no longer have to follow a fixed timetable. Clearly, online learning provides flexibility and convenience.*

**Structure:**

Supporting details → Examples → Topic sentence (main idea)

# 3. Complex Paragraph

**(Combination of both inductive and deductive)**

- The main idea appears **in the middle**, after some details and before the rest.
- Begins with **context or background**, presents the **main idea**, and ends with **further explanation or evidence**.
- Often used in **analytical or argumentative writing**, where the paragraph develops a more complex point.

**Example:**

*Many people assume that working from home reduces productivity. However, studies show that remote workers often complete more tasks in less time. This suggests that flexibility and autonomy can actually enhance work performance.*

**Structure:**

Supporting details → Topic sentence → Additional support or conclusion

# 4-Coherence

Coherence means the *quality of continuity and smoothness* in writing.

It makes your paragraph or essay flow logically, so the reader can easily follow your ideas from one sentence to the next.

In simple words — **coherence means your writing "makes sense" as a whole** and feels connected rather than jumping from one idea to another.

# Achieving Coherence through…

- **Ways to achieve coherence:**
  - Transitional expressions
  - Parallel structures
  - Use of personal pronouns

# Transitional expressions

- These are words or phrases that connect ideas and show relationships between them.
- They help the reader see how one idea leads to another.

# Some Useful Transitions

**To show addition:** again, and, also, besides, equally important, first (second, etc.), further, furthermore, in addition, in the first place, moreover, next, too

**To give examples:** for example, for instance, in fact, specifically, that is, to illustrate

**To compare:** although, and yet, at the same time, but, despite, even though, however, in contrast, in spite of, nevertheless, on the contrary, on the other hand, still, though, yet

**To show time:** after, afterward, as long as, as soon as, at last, before, during, earlier, finally, formerly, immediately, later, meanwhile, next, since, shortly, subsequently, then, thereafter, until, when, while

**To show place or direction:** above, below, beyond, close, elsewhere, farther on, here, nearby, opposite, to the left (north, etc.)

**To indicate logical relationship:** accordingly, as a result, because, consequently, for this reason, hence, if, otherwise, since, so, then, therefore, thus

**To summarize or conclude:** all in all, in conclusion, in other words, in short, in summary, on the whole, that is, therefore, to sum up

# Parallel Structures

- Parallelism means using the same grammatical structure for similar ideas.
- It creates balance and rhythm, making your writing easier to read.

She likes **to swim**, **jogging**, and **to read**. **(Not parallel)**

She likes **to swim**, **to jog**, and **to read**. **(Parallel)**

**Example for coherence:**

The company wants to **expand its market**, **increase sales**, and **improve customer service**.

# Use of Personal Pronouns

- Pronouns (like he, she, it, they, this, that, these, those) help connect sentences by referring to previously mentioned ideas or nouns.
- **Example:**
  The computer system was upgraded last week. **It** now runs much faster.

  Here, **it** refers back to *the computer system*, creating a link between the two sentences.

1. This year, I have tried to reduce my impact on the environment. 2. First, I am recycling more items. 3. For a long time, I have recycled glass, metal, and paper, but now I'm turning in old electronics to recycling programs. 4. Second, I have started a compost pile so that I'm not throwing away kitchen scraps like vegetable peels, coffee grinds, and egg shells. 5. The compost pile has the added benefit of providing rich soil for my garden. 6. This soil keeps my plants healthy so that I don't have to use pesticides. 7. Third, I have replaced all of the incandescent light bulbs in my house with fluorescent bulbs. 8. The fluorescent bulbs use less energy while providing good lighting. 9. These actions may seem minor, but I believe that even small steps can help our environment, especially if all of us take them.

Which is the topic sentence? Which are the body sentences? Which is the concluding sentence?

1. For new students, college can be both exciting and challenging. 2. On the one hand, they get exposed to many new ideas, new people, and new opportunities. 3. For example, they may study subjects that are entirely new to them. 4. Also, they meet a variety of students, some of whom may become study partners or even good friends. 5. On the other hand, college can place stress on new students. 6. For instance, students who are working or parenting children (or doing both) may find it difficult to make time to study. 7. Additionally, they may find college courses to be very difficult, especially if they have been out of school for several years. 8. The good news is that with persistence and the right support, many students can overcome these challenges and get everything out of college that they want to.

1. “Honesty is the best policy” goes the common saying, but is it really? 2. I always prefer to be honest, but a recent experience suggests that telling the truth can sometimes backfire. 3. Recently, my best friend asked me what I thought of her new boyfriend. 4. I thought he treated her disrespectfully, and he was also rude to me and her other friends. 5. However, because I didn’t want to hurt my friend’s feelings, I said, “You like him, and that’s enough for me.” 6. She would not accept my response and pushed further, saying, “You’re my best friend, so it’s really important for me to know what you think.” 7. Thus, I was honest—perhaps blunt. 8. I replied, “I think he’s a jerk to you.” 9. Since then, my friend has stopped speaking to me. 10. I think I acted properly given the circumstances; however, I might not be so honest in the future.

1. The fan behavior at the Roxinoids concert was the worst that I have ever seen. 2. Close to the stage, fans were pushing up against each other and throwing bottles and cans at the performers. 3. One guy climbed up onto the stage, but a security officer threw him back into the crowd. 4. Security guards should really be more careful. 5. Farther back in the concert hall, a woman lit a cigarette pack on fire and threw it into the air. 6. Fortunately, it landed on the ground and someone stamped out the flames. 7. By the back doors, a group of fans who came in late almost started a riot because they couldn't get closer to the stage. 8. Although the fan behavior was scary, the concert is definitely something I won't forget.

1. Which words improve coherence?
2. Which sentence should be deleted because it does not relate to the topic sentence?

1. Our two-year-old son Dante has a strict bedtime routine, and any break in it will lead to a sleepless night for everyone in the house. 2. First, he gets a bath, and we wash him and shampoo his hair. 3. Dante is unusually handsome for a two-year-old. 4. We let him play with his rubber duck so that he doesn't fuss in the tub. 5. When the bath is over, we dry Dante with a large towel and carry him to his room. 6. Next, we put a fresh diaper on him. 7. Then, we read him a bedtime story while gently rocking him in a rocking chair. 8. Finally, we lay him down in his crib and leave the room quietly with our fingers crossed, hoping he will fall asleep for the night.

1. Which words are transitions that improve coherence?
2. Which sentence should be deleted because it does not relate to the topic sentence?

1. I want to move to New York City because of its excitement and its culture. 2. The first quality that I love about New York is its busy street life. 3. I've seen street performers entertaining crowds at two in the morning! 4. New York was called "New Amsterdam" by Dutch colonists in the seventeenth century. 5. Even more attractive ~~to me are the museums, bookstores, galleries, and theaters that~~ make New York a center for the arts. 6. However, to me, the city's most important quality is the variety of people—from artists to businesspeople to struggling actors. 7. I love to just sit at a café and watch the human parade pass by. 8. I long to be a part of that parade.

1. Which words (or word groups) are transitions that improve coherence?
2. Which sentence should be deleted because it does not relate to the topic sentence?